

“Combining ideas creatively isn’t like shaking marbles in a bag. The marbles have to come together because there is some intelligible, though previously unnoticed, link between them which we value because it is interesting – illuminating, thought-provoking, humorous ... – in some way. We saw also that combinational creativity typically requires a very rich store of knowledge, of many different kinds, and the ability to form links of many different types.”

“And we don’t only form links, we evaluate them. For instance, we can recognize that a joke is “in bad taste”. In other words: yes, the links that the joker is suggesting are actually there (so it’s a real joke). But there are other links there also, which connect the ideas with sorrow, humiliation or tragedy. The joker should have noticed them, and should have refrained from reminding us of them.

“For a computer to make a subtle combinational joke, never mind to assess its tastefulness, would require (1) a data-base with a richness comparable to ours, and (2) methods of link-making (and link-evaluating) comparable in subtlety with ours.”

The one artificial intelligence system that continually comes up in discussions about joke-making is JAPE (Joke Analysis and Production Engine). Developed by British computer scientists Graeme Ritchie and Kim Binstead of the Edinburgh University, JAPE has the ability to tell the kinds of jokes you would find in an old *1001 jokes to tell your school friends* book.

In scientific terms, it generates punning riddles, from a linguistic model of puns, including a collection of high-level pun schemata, and a non-humour-specific lexicon w/ semantic, syntactic, phonological, and psycholinguistic information. JAPE is essentially an intelligent agent that’s contextually aware and has natural language processing capability to produce puns.

Here are a few example of the kinds of puns JAPE generates:

“What kind of E.T. drinks beer?” “An ale-ian.”

“What do you call a breakfast food murderer? A cereal killer.”

“What’s the difference between a dog and a painter? One can shed a coat and the other can coat a shed.”

“What’s the difference between a pretty glove and a silent cat? One is a cute mitten and then other is a mute kitten.”

In a field test, the researchers made a collection of JAPE jokes, human-made jokes and non-jokes of a similar part. These jokes were shown to